

Term Paper Checkpoint 3: Background and Structure

Hopefully by this point, you've got a really good sense of what material is available for you to build on for your term paper. You've got a set of formal research documents that you've analyzed, and a bunch of informal material to help flush out the ideas. In this step, we're going to use that to write our background section and start moving on to actually structuring the final paper.

Searches and Research Questions

If you are happy with your research questions, systematic, and unsystematic searches, and CRAAP analysis from your previous checkpoint, you can leave them unchanged (you'll still need to include them so that the reader can use them in analyzing the background sections and outlines). If you want to update them, this is your chance to do so. In theory, you can still make changes right up until the final term paper submission, but we're really building on that research now, so it's going to be more work to change topics/queries/questions from here on in. So think carefully about how happy you are with your progress thus far.

Background

All research papers start with a background section, which explains to the reader what fundamental material they need to be familiar with to understand this paper, and where this work sits in the context of the research landscape. There are three important questions that a background section needs to provide to a reader:

1. What work has already been done in this area
2. What that work has found to be true
3. How those findings relate to the current paper

The goal here isn't to give every single detail of the papers, or even to provide an exhaustive list of the research materials on which you're building. But rather to give the reader enough background to understand the landscape of the research you're building upon. Many of the papers in this section will be covered in more detail in later parts of the paper. This section is just about setting context.

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well, actually they start with an abstract and then an introduction, but we'll leave those for last

Your role

For each of the papers in your systematic and unsystematic search, you will write a 3 sentence summary that answers the questions above: What does this work actually do? What did it find? And why the reader should care about those findings. If you take some time to really structure this part, you should be able to just copy & paste these together, with maybe a bit of connective material to explain groupings and common themes, into your final paper.

Paper Outline

Now that you have your research questions sorted, and some background research to build upon. It's time to start structuring your term paper. There's a lot of flexibility in how you actually put your paper together, but it's important to have a plan and a structure to build on.

Your Role

Write up a point-form outline of your final term paper. With each section/subsection having a one sentence summary of what goes there. This outline should be enough to explain where your research questions will be addressed, and how they will be brought together to form a conclusion or summary analysis.

An example outline might look something like this (of course, yours will be in a lot more detail):

- Introduction
 - Explain why dog videogames are important, and introduce the research questions
- Background
 - Summaries of 20 systematic + 20 unsystematic search items
- History of Video Games for Dogs
 - Videogames as training tools for military dogs
 - Videogames as toys for bored dogs
 - The dog videogame boom of the early 2010s
 - The anti-dog-videogame movement
- Dog Enjoyment of Video Games
 - Analysis of dog videogame sales, and whether they are driven by dogs or owners
 - Analysis of metrics for measuring whether dogs enjoy videogames
- Dog Training with Video Games
 - Discussion of studies on sheep dog training

- Discussion of studies of home dog training
- Discussion of studies of service dog training
- Possible Harms of Video Games for Dogs
 - Analysis of papers on impacts of videogames on dogs eyesight
 - Addressing rumours of harm caused by smell-o-vision controllers
 - Analysis of claims that dog videogames are responsible for the decline in walkies times
 - * Analysis of whether decline is actually supported by data
 - * Analysis of whether decline can be attributed to video games
- Conclusion
 - Summary of findings
 - Answers to research questions
 - Statement of author's personal opinion

What to Submit

In a single document, you must submit:

- Your research questions
- Your systematic search
- Your unsystematic search
- Your CRAAP analysis for each of the documents
- Your background summaries for each document
- Your point form outline of your final paper